

2.4 Variable Names

[This section corresponds to K&R Sec. 2.1]

Within limits, you can give your variables and functions any names you want. These names (the formal term is ``identifiers'') consist of letters, numbers, and underscores. For our purposes, names must begin with a letter. Theoretically, names can be as long as you want, but extremely long ones get tedious to type after a while, and the compiler is not required to keep track of extremely long ones perfectly. (What this means is that if you were to name a variable, say, `supercalafragalisticespialidocious`, the compiler might get lazy and pretend that you'd named it `supercalafragalisticespialidocio`, such that if you later misspelled it `supercalafragalisticespialidociouz`, the compiler wouldn't catch your mistake. Nor would the compiler necessarily be able to tell the difference if for some perverse reason you *deliberately* declared a second variable named `supercalafragalisticespialidociouz`.)

The capitalization of names in C is significant: the variable names `variable`, `Variable`, and `VARIABLE` (as well as silly combinations like `variAble`) are all distinct.

A final restriction on names is that you may not use *keywords* (the words such as `int` and `for` which are part of the syntax of the language) as the names of variables or functions (or as identifiers of any kind).

Read sequentially: [prev](#) [next](#) [up](#) [top](#)

This page by [Steve Summit](#) // [Copyright](#) 1995, 1996 // [mail feedback](#)